

System Context Brief

IIIT Hyderabad Breakfast Mess System

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System Boundary and Context

System Boundary

The system under study is the breakfast meal registration, billing, and service process operated across the four residential dining messes at IIIT Hyderabad — Kadamba, Palash, Bakul, and Yuktāhār — together with the digital registration and billing platform (dining.iiit.ac.in) that governs access to all four. The boundary includes the interface between this system and the academic class schedule, since the two operate on overlapping but independently controlled timings.

On-campus alternatives that compete for the same demand — Vindhya Canteen, the juice canteens, and third-party food delivery services — sit at the edge of this boundary. They are not part of the mess system’s own operation, but they materially affect it: a student who does not eat at a mess draws instead on one of these.

Lunch and dinner registration at the same four messes fall outside this boundary. The system described here is scoped to the breakfast meal, though it runs on the same underlying platform and the same rules as the other two meals.

Context

The breakfast system serves the entire resident student population of the institute across four messes, operating daily from 7:30 AM to 9:30 AM. Total confirmed breakfast capacity across the four messes is approxi-

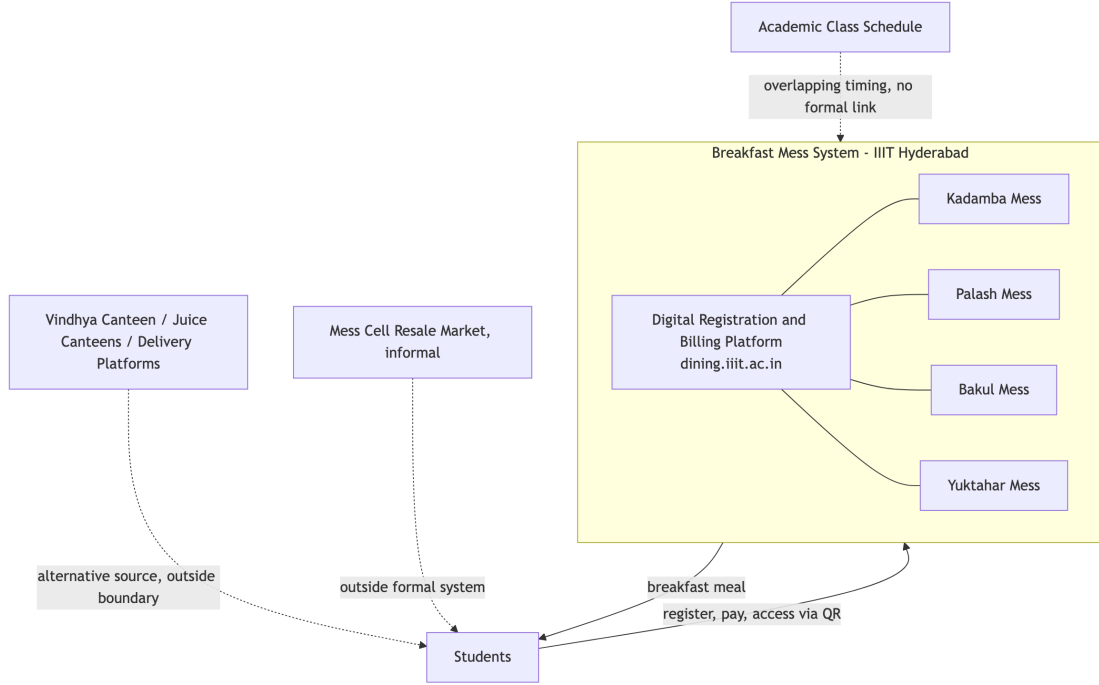


Figure 1: System Boundary

mately 2,755 registrations per day: Kadamba (700 vegetarian, 600 non-vegetarian), Bakul (350 vegetarian, 350 non-vegetarian), Palāsh (400), and Yuktāhār (340 regular, 15 Jain).

Structurally, the system combines centralized demand management with decentralized supply. A single digital platform governs registration, billing, and access across all four messes, while food production itself is distributed and non-uniform, and organized around cuisine rather than being interchangeable outlets. Kadamba serves South Indian food, vegetarian and non-vegetarian, and operates its own kitchen and vendor. Palash serves North Indian vegetarian food and cannot produce non-vegetarian food at all. Bakul serves North Indian food, vegetarian and non-vegetarian: its vegetarian food is cooked at Palash and physically transported to Bakul, while its non-vegetarian food is prepared on-site. Yuktāhār serves Jain-oriented food, with a separate Jain registration variant, and operates independently. Food procurement is handled separately by each mess’s own vendor, not centrally. Four different cuisines, kitchens, and procurement arrangements are unified only at the registration, billing, and access layer — the mess system is not one kitchen serving one population through one process, but a coordinated platform sitting over four structurally different operations.

The system operates inside, and is shaped by, several adjacent systems it does not control:

- **Academic administration and class schedule.** Classes begin at 8:30 AM and run until 6:40 PM, with a class lunch break from 1:00 PM to 2:00 PM. Class scheduling is not continuous — most students have a limited number of classes on a given day — and there is no formal channel of coordination between the mess system and the academic calendar; the two schedules are set independently of one another by separate authorities.
- **Warden, Mess Committee, and Mess Office governance.** Mess governance is split across three actors. The Mess Committee is a policy body, chaired by a faculty member, that sets the menu and mess-specific policy, incorporating student input approximately one month ahead of service. The Mess Office is the operational arm: it places food orders with each vendor on a four-day lead time, administers the registration platform, and issues operational policy changes — a policy change tightening cancellation rules was issued by the Mess Office specifically to reduce staff workload. The Warden holds authority over vendor management and structural changes to the mess; the working relationship

between the Warden and the Mess Office is not established.

- **An informal peer-to-peer resale market (“Mess Cell”).** A WhatsApp group has formed in which students who hold a breakfast registration they will not use offer it for resale to other students at a negotiated price below the registered rate. This market operates entirely outside the mess system’s own registration and billing infrastructure, transacted through the same personal QR-based access credential the formal system issues.
- **The wider campus food ecosystem.** Vindhya Canteen (open Monday to Saturday, from 10:00 AM), the juice canteens (open mornings), and delivery platforms (accepting orders until 11:00 PM, with delivery personnel required to remain outside the campus gate) all draw on the same student population and stand as alternatives to mess breakfast.

Billing operates on a monthly cycle tied to registration, not attendance: a student is charged for every meal they are registered for, regardless of whether they eat it, and may cancel a registration in advance, subject to a limit of five cancellations per meal type per month. Unregistered (“walk-in”) access to a meal is priced materially higher than registered access to the same meal.

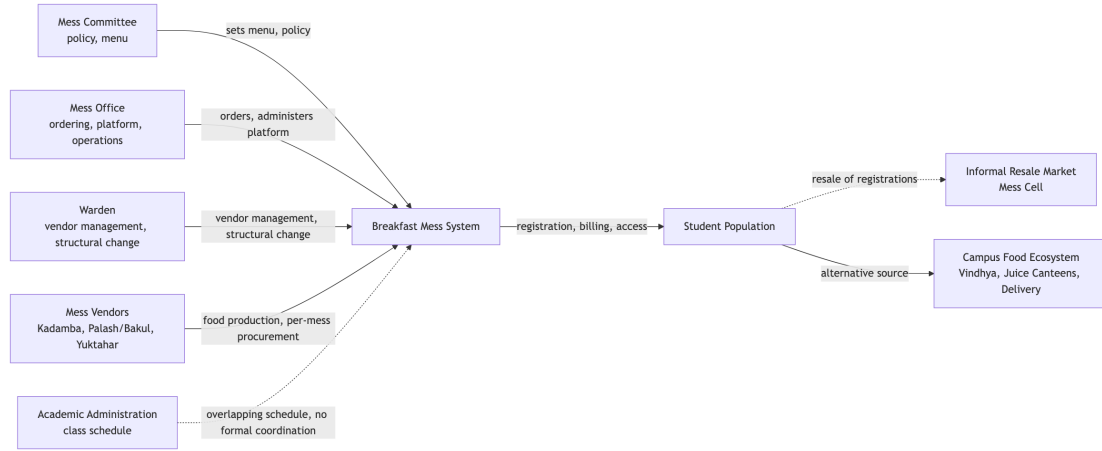


Figure 2: Context Map

Purpose and Intended Outcomes

Purpose

The breakfast mess system exists to provide the resident student population with reliable, adequate, good-quality food each morning, at a predictable and affordable cost, accommodating dietary requirements — vegetarian, non-vegetarian, and Jain — in a manner that supports student health, energy, and academic performance.

Intended Outcomes

- Every registered student obtains a breakfast meal matching their dietary requirement within the operating window.
- Food quality and preparation quantity remain consistent with actual demand, minimizing both shortage and waste.
- The cost structure remains affordable and predictable for students across a full semester.
- Access to breakfast does not depend on a student’s ability to navigate informal workarounds; the formal system functions as the primary and sufficient channel on its own.
- The system remains responsive to changes in student needs and circumstances — schedule conflicts, dietary changes, feedback — through its own governance structure.

Visible Symptoms and Underlying Issues

Visible Symptom	Underlying Issue
A student registers for breakfast, does not attend, and is still charged the full registered price.	Billing is tied to registration, not attendance. The cost is incurred at the point of registering, independent of whether the meal is ultimately consumed.
The registration platform imposes a cap of five cancellations per meal type per month.	Uncancelled, unattended registrations occur often enough, across the student population, that an explicit limit was necessary to manage them — the cap is itself evidence of the scale of the pattern it constrains.
A “Skip Meal” function lets a student notify the kitchen in advance that they will not attend, but this does not reduce or refund the charge.	The mechanism built for anticipated non-attendance addresses only the kitchen’s production planning, not the student’s cost. It returns zero value to the student for the same situation a cancellation — capped at five per month — would address instead.
An unofficial, student-run resale market (“Mess Cell”) has formed, where students sell registrations they will not use to other students at a negotiated price.	Reselling a registration returns partial or full value to the student, while using Skip Meal returns none. For a student who knows in advance they will not attend, resale is a materially better option than the system’s own built-in mechanism for the same situation — the formal tool is outcompeted by an informal one because it was designed to reduce kitchen waste, not to return value to the student.
Registered-but-unclaimed meals persist despite both a cancellation option and a resale market being available.	Cancellation and resale both require advance knowledge that the student will not attend. Non-attendance decided at the last minute — oversleeping, running out of time, a change of plans — has no mechanism available to it at all; this is the specific category of registration that converts into prepared, uneaten food with no value returned to anyone.
Walk-in (unregistered) access to a meal costs substantially more than the same meal accessed through a prior registration.	The pricing structure creates a standing incentive to register in advance even when attendance is uncertain, since deciding same-day costs more. Registration counts are inflated by this incentive independent of a student’s actual intention to attend.
Registered breakfast attendance is markedly lower, relative to capacity, at every mess serving North Indian food (Palash, Bakul) than at Kadamba, the South Indian mess — Kadamba runs 51-79% uptake against 11-36.5% at the North Indian lines.	The gap tracks cuisine, not any single mess’s individual circumstances — it holds consistently across three independently operated messes sharing that one variable. Bakul’s status as a newer mess, housed in a converted warehouse with part of its food transported in from Palash, remains a contributing factor, but the cuisine pattern is the stronger and better-evidenced explanation for the low uptake.

Visible Symptom	Underlying Issue
Neither students nor mess-side staff describe a specific example of mess feedback leading to a change in policy, hours, or operations.	Three real channels carry student input into the system — an in-app per-meal rating captured after every meal, a public email address for raising mess issues, and coverage of mess problems in Ping, the student publication. None of the three has a confirmed instance of producing a policy change. The overlap between breakfast hours and the academic schedule has never been formally raised for the same reason: there is no established path for a cross-authority issue to be escalated by either side, and no evidence that raising an issue through any existing channel changes an outcome. The Mess Committee, Mess Office, and Warden together control mess operations; the academic administration controls class scheduling; neither side has authority over the other’s schedule, and no coordination mechanism links the two. A timing conflict between them can persist indefinitely without either side being positioned to resolve it unilaterally.
Breakfast hours (7:30–9:30 AM) overlap with the start of the academic day (8:30 AM), while the two schedules are set by entirely separate authorities. Real interview data confirms this is not only a scheduling inconvenience but an explicit trade-off: a student who wakes late enough to conflict with an 8:30 class reports prioritizing class attendance over breakfast specifically because of the academic attendance policy. The registration platform includes a random-allocation mechanism, evidenced by a settings option to notify a student when they have been randomly allocated a meal.	Some registrations are generated by the system itself rather than by active student choice. Recorded registration counts do not uniformly represent expressed intent to attend. Breakfast non-attendance is not driven by a single cause. It includes a population of students whose non-attendance would persist regardless of any change to mess hours, pricing, or process, because the driving factor is a personal routine formed independently of the mess system. Breakfast attendance, for at least part of the student population, is a socially coordinated decision rather than a purely individual one; a student’s own registration does not reliably predict their attendance independent of who else is going that morning.
A portion of students report skipping breakfast for reasons unrelated to the mess system’s own operation — personal dietary practice, sleep schedule, and established habit.	
Students report that companionship affects whether they attend breakfast — attendance is more likely when a roommate or friend is also going.	

Key Actors, Institutions, Processes, Resources and Constraints

Actors

- **Students** — the registrants and consumers of the meal; attendance and dietary preference vary across the population.
- **Mess Committee** — a faculty-chaired policy body that sets the menu and mess-specific policy, incorporating student input approximately one month in advance.

- **Mess Office** — the operational and administrative arm; places food orders with each vendor, administers the registration platform, and issues operational policy changes.
- **Warden** — holds authority over vendor management and structural changes to the mess.
- **Per-mess vendors** — Kadamba’s vendor (South Indian); the shared Palash/Bakul vendor (North Indian); Yuktāhār’s vendor (Jain-oriented).
- **Mess serving and cleaning staff** — also consume mess food after student service hours conclude.
- **Academic administration** — sets the class schedule; holds no authority over mess operations.
- **Students participating in the Mess Cell resale market** — an unofficial secondary role occupied by a subset of registered students.
- **Guests** — parents, visiting relatives, and non-student campus affiliates who pay the vendor directly for access.

Institutions

- The Mess Committee (policy), the Mess Office (operations), and the Office of the Warden (vendor management and structural change) — three separate governance actors holding different parts of mess governance.
- The academic administration/timetable authority, operating independently with no formal link to any of the three mess-governance actors.
- The four mess vendors, each handling its own procurement and cooking, operating as independent entities under one shared registration platform.

Processes

- **Registration** — a student selects a mess and meal date through the digital platform in advance of service.
- **Billing** — charges are applied monthly, calculated from registration count, independent of attendance.
- **Cancellation** — a registered meal may be cancelled in advance, up to five times per meal type per month, removing the associated charge.
- **Skip Meal** — a registered student may flag in advance that they will not attend; this notifies the kitchen for production planning but does not affect billing.
- **Access** — a student presents a personal QR code at the mess counter to receive a plate matching their registered dietary category. The code can be reset at any time, and mess staff can reassign it on the spot if a student eats at a different mess than the one registered.
- **Walk-in access** — a student without a registration may pay the vendor directly at a higher rate, subject to a separate, smaller capacity allocation.
- **Resale** — outside the formal platform, a registered student may transfer their registration to another student through the Mess Cell WhatsApp group, in exchange for a negotiated payment.
- **Menu setting** — the Mess Committee finalizes the menu approximately one month ahead of service, incorporating student input.
- **Food ordering** — the Mess Office places an order with each vendor four days ahead of service; vendors prepare food against that four-day-old figure, not against same-day registration or cancellation activity.
- **Feedback intake** — student input reaches the system through an in-app per-meal rating, a public email address, and coverage in the student publication Ping; none of the three has a confirmed record of producing a resulting policy change.

Resources

- The digital registration and billing platform (dining.iiit.ac.in).
- Four physical mess facilities of differing capacity and origin — Kadamba (purpose-built, largest capacity), Bakul (a converted warehouse), and Palash and Yuktāhār as separate facilities.
- Per-mess food production capacity, distributed unevenly by cuisine — Kadamba (South Indian) and Yuktāhār (Jain-oriented) produce on-site; Bakul’s North Indian vegetarian supply is transported from Palash while its non-vegetarian food is prepared on-site; each vendor procures its own ingredients

- independently.
- The personal QR access credential issued to each student.

Constraints

- Billing is registration-based, not attendance-based, and cancellations are capped at five per meal type per month.
- Walk-in pricing is set materially higher than registered pricing.
- Vegetarian and non-vegetarian food is segregated by registration type at the point of service.
- Palash's kitchen cannot produce non-vegetarian food — a fixed physical limitation, not a policy choice.
- Mess operating hours and the academic class schedule are set independently by separate authorities, with no formal coordination mechanism between them.
- Governance authority over mess operations is split across the Mess Committee, the Mess Office, and the Warden; the academic administration has no formal role in mess-related decisions.
- Vendors order and prepare food against a four-day-old registration figure; nothing in the system lets same-day registration, cancellation, or Skip Meal activity change what is actually cooked.

Initial Problem Framing

Many students register for breakfast and do not eat it. The meal is still cooked, and the student is still charged.

The system gives students two ways to avoid this: cancel the registration, or mark it as skipped. Skip Meal returns no money to the student — only cancellation does, and only five times a month per meal. Both require the student to decide in advance. A student who decides at the last minute has no option at all, and that meal is simply wasted. Students have built their own workaround outside the system — reselling registrations to each other — because it pays back more than the system's own tools do.

The problem: registration does not reliably reflect who is actually going to eat. Why not, and what in the system is causing that gap?

Stakeholder Map

IIIT Hyderabad Breakfast Mess System

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Use Case

The breakfast mess system at IIIT Hyderabad registers, bills, and serves breakfast to the resident student population across four messes — Kadamba, Palash, Bakul, and Yuktāhār — through a single digital platform. Registration counts, not attendance, drive billing and food procurement. This map identifies every actor, institution, and informal structure that participates in, influences, benefits from, or is affected by this system, and the relationships, dependencies, and conflicts between them.

Stakeholders

Primary, Secondary, and Indirect Stakeholders

Twenty-seven candidate actors were identified across seventeen analytical lenses (student/user, social, food production, governance, money, technology, academic, sleep/time-use, substitute systems, campus infrastructure, waste, health, policy, informal systems, absent/sleeping stakeholders, temporal, and intervention). Seventeen are included in the final map. Four were considered and treated as minor rather than included in full (cleaning staff, juice canteens specifically, and campus security/gate staff — real but with no evidence of independent leverage beyond what is already captured through serving staff, Vindhya, and delivery platforms; guest diners — real but marginal in volume). Three were considered and excluded entirely: a campus health/wellbeing office (no evidence connects it to breakfast-skipping), senior-to-junior norm transmission, and a parental financial relationship (mess fees are bundled into hostel fees, not paid per meal).

Primary stakeholders — direct, daily interaction with the system:

Stakeholder	Type
Students	Human group — registrant, billed party, consumer
Vendor — South Indian (Kadamba)	Commercial
Vendor — North Indian (Palash veg-only + Bakul veg/non-veg)	Commercial
Vendor — Jain (Yuktāhār)	Commercial
Mess serving/counter staff	Human group
Kitchen/cooking staff	Human group

Secondary stakeholders — govern, execute, or manage the system without daily direct interaction:

Stakeholder	Type
Mess Committee	Institution — policy
Mess Office	Institution — operations
Warden	Individual role — vendor management, structural change
Student Parliament Mess Secretary, and a Mess Deputy Secretary per mess (Kadamba, Palash, Yuktāhār)	Elected individual roles — student representation on mess matters

Indirect stakeholders — affected by or connected to the system without direct engagement, including latent (“sleeping”) actors currently inert but holding potential leverage:

Stakeholder	Type
Academic administration / timetable authority	Institution — latent
Facilities/Estate team	Institution — latent
Portal/IT system owner	Institution or individual — latent
Mess Cell WhatsApp community	Informal group
Unofficial mess-tool developers	Individual(s) — latent
Ping (student publication)	Institution — latent
Vindhya Canteen and juice canteens	Commercial — substitute
Delivery platforms and riders	Commercial — substitute

Stakeholder Interests, Needs, and Expectations

Stakeholder	Interest	Need	Expectation
Students	Convenient, affordable, timely food; not paying twice for a missed meal	A functioning registration and billing system, predictable operating hours, food matching their dietary registration	Registering for a meal reliably results in being fed if they attend; being charged regardless of attendance is a known, tolerated rule rather than an agreed one

Stakeholder	Interest	Need	Expectation
Vendor — South Indian (Kadamba)	Contract renewal, predictable order volume, margin	An accurate registration forecast with enough lead time to procure — currently four days ahead of service (previously two)	The four-day forecast approximates real demand
Vendor — North Indian (Palash + Bakul)	Contract renewal, predictable order volume, margin	Same four-day forecast lead time; Palash’s kitchen cannot produce non-vegetarian food, a fixed limitation on its role	Demand for the vegetarian line cooked at Palash and transported to Bakul stays predictable
Vendor — Jain (Yuktāhār)	Contract renewal, predictable order volume, margin	Same four-day forecast lead time; relationship to the other two vendors (shared or independent) unconfirmed	Same as other vendors
Serving and kitchen staff	Manageable preparation and service load, predictable headcounts	Sufficient lead time and an accurate registration count	Leftover food is theirs to consume after student service hours — an informal norm, not a written entitlement
Mess Committee	Balancing student satisfaction against operational feasibility	A functioning process for gathering and interpreting student input	The existing student-input process for the menu constitutes sufficient engagement on mess matters generally, including matters — hours, billing — that process was never designed to cover
Mess Office	Reduced operational workload — the confirmed, stated motive behind its one policy change on record	An accurate same-day picture of intent, currently unavailable at less than four days’ notice	Registration counts are a workable proxy for actual attendance
Warden	Stable vendor relationships, orderly mess infrastructure	Clear division of responsibility with the Mess Office	Vendor management and structural authority remain within the Warden’s own lane
Student Parliament Mess Secretary / per-mess Deputy Secretaries	Representing student interests on mess matters	A working channel into the Mess Committee and Mess Office	Not established — whether this elected seat carries a vote in the institute-level Mess Committee, or only in a separate Parliament-internal mess committee, is unconfirmed

Stakeholder	Interest	Need	Expectation
Academic administration	Its own domain — class scheduling — run without external interference	No stated need connects it to mess operations	No expectation of any relationship to mess governance; confirmed to hold no formal mess role
Facilities/Estate team	Physical infrastructure upkeep	Authorization and budget for mess-facility work (the Kadamba renovation is confirmed to have occurred)	Not established — identity of this actor is itself unconfirmed
Portal/IT system owner	System uptime and reliability of the registration interface	Not established	Not established — no source names this actor
Mess Cell WhatsApp community	Recovering value from a registration that will go unused	A way to transfer a registration since Skip Meal returns no money	Buyers and sellers can find each other informally and transact on trust
Unofficial mess-tool developers	Not established beyond building the tool itself	Not established	Described in the tool’s own documentation as built “for students of IIIT Hyderabad”
Ping (student publication)	Reporting on mess issues as a matter of student interest	Access to information worth publishing	Not established whether coverage produces any institutional response
Vindhya Canteen and juice canteens	Capturing demand when mess breakfast is skipped or unavailable	Steady walk-in customer flow	Not established
Delivery platforms and riders	Capturing demand when mess breakfast is skipped or unavailable	Gate access for delivery, currently restricted	Not established

Formal and Informal Roles

Formal roles attach to every institutional and commercial actor: Students (as registrant), Mess Committee, Mess Office, Warden, the three vendors, serving and kitchen staff, Vindhya Canteen and juice canteens, and delivery platforms all hold a formal, rule-defined position in the system.

Informal roles attach to the Mess Cell WhatsApp community, Ping, and the unofficial mess-tool developers — none of these has any official standing in the system, yet each performs a real function (resale market, public-pressure channel, and an alternative registration interface, respectively).

Roles that are not separate stakeholders. Several categories that might appear as distinct actors are, on inspection, behavioral states or temporary roles occupied by the single actor Students, not separate stakeholders in their own right: attending regularly, skipping regularly, having an early class on a given day, buying or selling on Mess Cell, and using an unofficial registration tool are all states a single student may move through within the same week. Peer influence between students — a roommate or friend’s presence changing whether a given student attends on a given morning — is an internal relationship on the Students node, not a separate “Friends” or “Roommates” stakeholder. Guest diners (relatives, visiting parents, non-student campus affiliates who pay a vendor directly) are the one genuine exception: they hold a materially different formal relationship — no registration or monthly billing cycle — but their volume is too marginal

to warrant inclusion as a full stakeholder.

Create the Map

Stakeholder Map

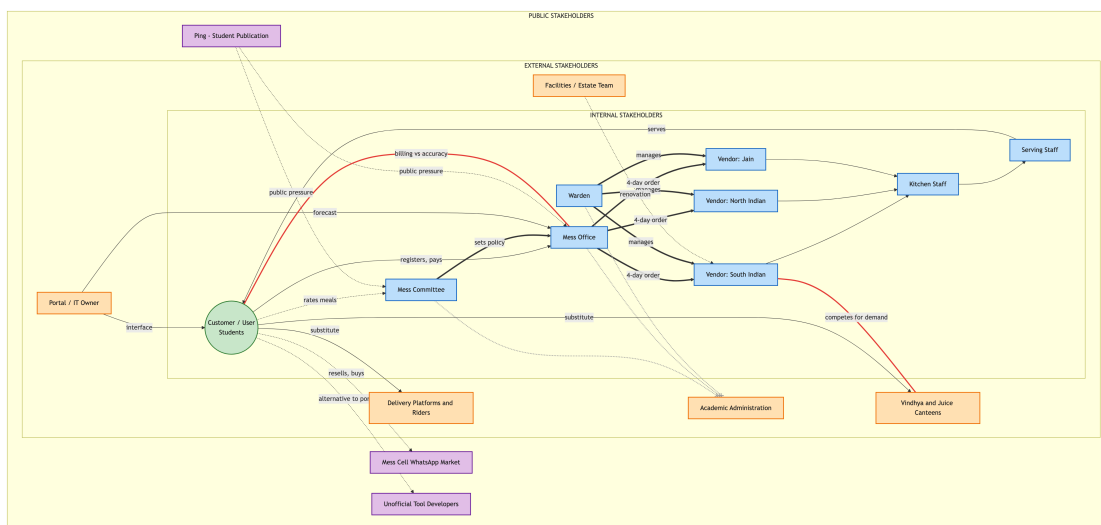


Figure 1: Stakeholder Map

Legend — relationship types

Style	Relationship
Solid line, plain label	Relation
Dotted line	Unclear, informal relationship
Thick line	Institutional relationship
Solid arrow, labeled	Directed flow of information
Red line	Relationship with conflict potential
Dotted line ending in X	Interrupted relationship (no confirmed connection)

Placement follows the standard four-ring model. **Customer/user:** Students. **Internal stakeholders:** Mess Committee, Mess Office, Warden, the three vendors, and serving and kitchen staff — the mess system’s own operating structure. **External stakeholders:** Academic administration, the Facilities/Estate team, the Portal/IT owner, Vindhya and the juice canteens, and delivery platforms — organizations that interact with the system’s boundary from outside it. **Public stakeholders:** the Mess Cell WhatsApp community, unofficial tool developers, and Ping — informal, public-facing actors with no institutional standing in the system.

Relationship Network

This second view lays out the same seventeen stakeholders by functional cluster — core daily operation, governance, and informal/competing — rather than by ring distance, making the full set of information, money, and authority flows easier to trace end to end.

Proximity to the Student’s Lived Experience

This third view clusters the same actors by closeness to a student’s actual morning rather than by relationship type. It surfaces a different finding from the two maps above: Academic administration sits at the outermost

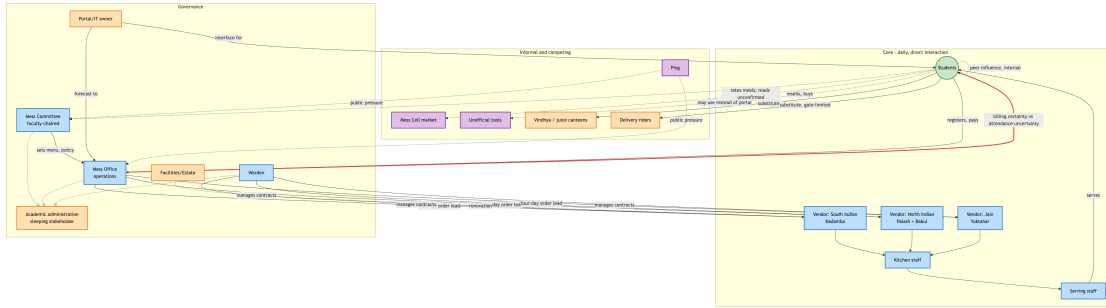


Figure 2: Relationship Network

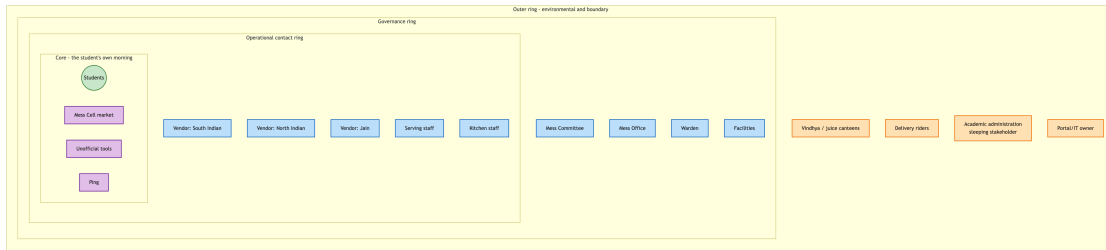


Figure 3: Onion Proximity Map

ring with no adjacent relationship connecting it inward at any layer, while Mess Cell, the unofficial tools, and Ping — none of them part of the formal governance structure — sit at the innermost ring alongside the students themselves.

Relationships, Dependencies, and Conflicts

Relationship Matrix

Cells marked *hypothesis* have not been independently confirmed.

	Students	Mess Committee	Mess Office	Warden	Academic admin.	Vendors	Staff	Mess Cell	Ping
Students	—	Feedback (rating system confirmed to exist; whether read is unconfirmed)	Registration, payment	—	Dependent on its schedule	Payment, service	Service	Payment, service	—
Mess Committee	Authority (menu, feedback)	—	Authority (sets policy)	Hypothesis: overlap	No relationship of any kind	Authority (menu)	—	—	Hypothesis: subject of coverage

	Students	Mess Commit- tee	Mess Office	Warden	Academic admin.	Vendors	Staff	Mess Cell	Ping
Mess Office	Billing, depen- dent on for order accuracy	Reports to (hypoth- esis)	—	Hypothesis overlap	No rela- tionship of any kind	Authority, depen- dency (order- ing)	Authority	—	Hypothesis: subject of cov- erage
Warden	—	Hypothesis	Hypothesis	—	No rela- tionship of any kind	Authority (con- tracts)	—	—	—
Vendors	Payment, food/material	Authority over	Authority over, depen- dency	Contract author- ity	—	—	Manages	—	—
Mess Cell	Payment, service, informal influence	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—

The empty and no-relationship cells are as significant as the populated ones. Academic administration has no confirmed relationship of any kind to any of the three governance actors — a genuine structural gap, not a modeling omission, and the single most consequential finding in this map.

Dependencies

Students depend on vendors for food quality and timing; vendors do not depend on any individual student — an asymmetric dependency consistent with a walk-in pricing structure that requires no negotiation. Vendors depend on the Mess Office for a registration forecast fixed four days ahead of service; the Mess Office depends on students to register accurately, but nothing in the billing structure requires accuracy, since a student is charged identically whether or not they attend — the weakest link in this dependency chain is also the one with no incentive attached to it. The Mess Committee depends on the Mess Office to execute policy; the Mess Office’s own stated motivation for its one confirmed policy change (reducing workload) did not visibly originate from or require Mess Committee direction, suggesting operational pressure may drive policy from below at least as often as governance drives it from above.

Beyond the Academic administration gap already noted: no source describes a direct relationship between vendors and students — all communication routes through the Mess Office or the portal. No source describes the Portal/IT owner having any direct relationship with the Mess Committee, despite the Committee setting policy this system presumably enforces technically.

Conflicts

Conflict	Side A	Side B
Billing certainty vs. attendance uncertainty	Mess Office and vendors need a stable number to order against, fixed four days ahead	Students face genuinely uncertain day-to-day attendance, with no incentive built into billing to report it accurately

Conflict	Side A	Side B
Flexibility vs. workload	Students and the Mess Cell market want more cancellation and resale flexibility	The Mess Office’s one confirmed policy change tightened rules specifically to reduce staff workload
Convenience vs. waste	Students want flexible registration	The Mess Office wants predictable, low-workload ordering
Cuisine demand vs. fixed procurement	Registered uptake is markedly lower at every North Indian line (Palash, Bakul) than at the South Indian line (Kadamba)	The four cuisine lines are fixed by vendor contract, not adjusted in response to demand
Academic schedule vs. meal schedule	Academic administration owns class timing and holds no stake in mess outcomes	Students bear the actual cost of the 8:30 AM overlap with breakfast hours

Findings

Twenty-seven candidate stakeholders were narrowed to seventeen through direct evidence rather than assumption; three lenses that might plausibly have produced a stakeholder — student health, senior-junior norm transmission, and a parental financial relationship — produced none.

The Mess Office is a distinct actor from the Mess Committee, separating “who decides policy” from “who executes it.” Every earlier account of this system’s governance, including this team’s own first drafts, had collapsed the two into one. The Mess Office places food orders on a four-day lead time, administers the registration platform, and issued the one confirmed policy change on record — driven by reducing staff workload, not a student-facing goal.

Academic administration holds the single lever most likely to materially affect the core problem — the overlap between breakfast hours and the 8:30 AM class start — and has no relationship of any kind, formal or informal, to any of the three mess-governance actors. This is the clearest sleeping stakeholder in the map: total authority over the one variable in conflict, zero engagement with the system it conflicts with.

Three real feedback channels exist — an in-app per-meal rating, a public email address, and coverage in Ping, the student publication — and none has a confirmed instance of producing a policy change. Inputs exist; a confirmed output does not.

Registered attendance is markedly lower, relative to capacity, at every mess serving North Indian food than at the South Indian mess, a pattern consistent across three independently operated messes rather than one, making cuisine preference a stronger candidate explanation for the uptake gap than any single mess’s individual circumstances.

The Mess Committee’s chair — reported in a secondhand, not directly verified source as a faculty member — is a second, more subtle candidate sleeping stakeholder if that report holds: an individual with cross-institutional standing that no student-only channel possesses, and a structurally plausible bridge to Academic administration, with no evidence that bridge has ever been used.

A directly verified addition since this map was first drawn: the Student Parliament maintains an elected Mess Secretary and a Mess Deputy Secretary for each mess (Kadamba, Palash, Yuktāhār), confirmed directly from the Parliament’s own published records — not a secondhand source. This is a real, structured channel of student representation that the three diagrams above do not yet depict; it belongs on the Internal ring alongside the Mess Committee, Mess Office, and Warden, and is carried forward into the Power–Interest/Leverage Map (Task 3) in full.

Two structurally hidden actors carry outsized influence without being visible to any single respondent: the Portal/IT system owner, interacted with constantly and named by no one, and the four-day procurement

Stakeholder Map

IIIT Hyderabad Breakfast Mess System

17 stakeholders • Four-ring model

Goal
Understand all stakeholders, their relationships and potential conflicts in the mess system.

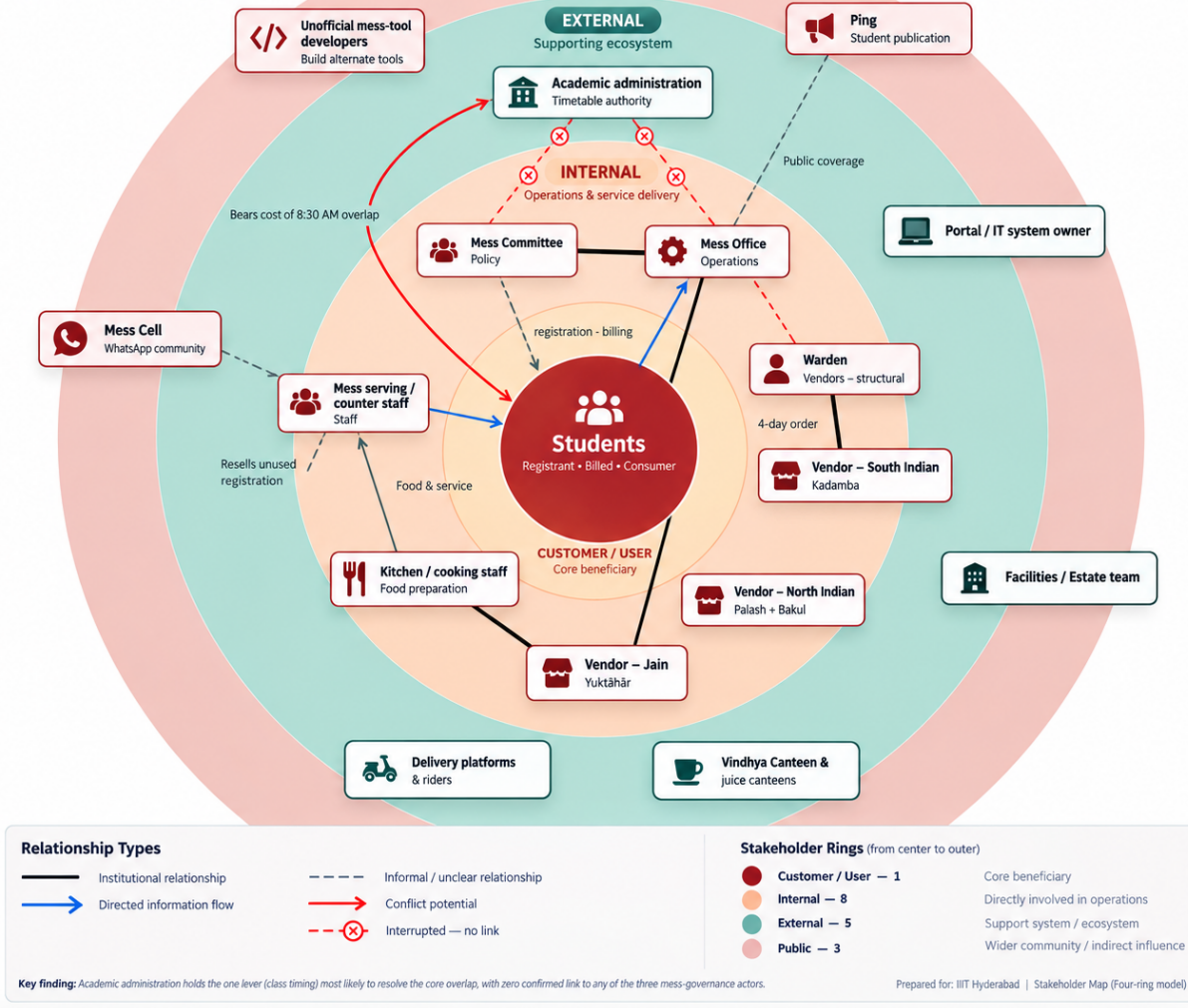


Figure 4: Consolidated Stakeholder Map, Four-Ring Overview

lead time itself — not a person, but a fixed constraint that caps how responsive the entire system can be to any same-day signal, including Skip Meal, regardless of which stakeholder wants to act on it.

Stakeholder Power-Interest/Leverage Map and Power Analysis Brief

IIIT Hyderabad Breakfast Mess System

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Executive Summary

Power in this system is not concentrated in one actor and does not move as a single current. It is split across three separate governance bodies whose relationship to one another is only partly established; it is exercised informally by actors with no official standing at all; and its most consequential feature is an absence rather than a presence — the complete lack of any relationship between the one actor who controls the class schedule and the three actors who control everything else about breakfast.

The central finding of this analysis: the actor who bears the full cost of the registration-attendance gap (the student) controls the one input every other actor’s planning depends on (registration intent), while bearing no cost for supplying that input inaccurately — a structurally unusual position that is neither straightforwardly powerful nor straightforwardly powerless.

Two findings in this brief were revised on new evidence rather than merely extended: a confirmed student representative structure on mess matters (the Student Parliament’s Mess Secretary and per-mess Deputy Secretaries — see the Stakeholder Map for the addition this made there), and a confirmed prior instance of organized student action aimed directly at governance, not only at peer-to-peer transactions. What remains genuinely unresolved — vendor compensation, the exact relationship between a Parliament-internal mess committee and the institute-level Mess Committee, and what that organized action was specifically about — is stated as open, not guessed at, and is listed in full at the end of this document.

Power is treated throughout as issue-specific rather than a single score per actor: a stakeholder may hold high authority over one decision and none over an adjacent one. Every claim below states which domain it applies to and distinguishes formal authority from observed influence.

Assess Decision-Making Authority

Formal governance structure

Three separate institutional actors hold mess governance — a split not recognized in this project’s own earlier drafts, where “who decides” and “who executes” had been collapsed into one actor:

- **Mess Committee** — a policy body that sets the menu approximately one month ahead of service, with student input. That this body is genuinely separate from the Mess Office is confirmed. That it is chaired by a faculty member traces to a search-engine snippet of a student-publication article that could not be directly verified in full — this specific detail is unconfirmed, though the Committee/Office split itself is not in question. Its authority beyond menu content is unconfirmed.
- **Mess Office** — the operational and administrative arm: places food orders on a four-day lead time, administers the registration platform, and issues operational policy changes. The one confirmed policy action on record — a December 2024 tightening of cancellation rules — was issued by this office alone, with its stated motive being reduced staff workload rather than a student-facing goal.
- **Warden** — holds authority over vendor management and structural changes to the mess. No source describes the Warden taking a specific action; this authority is stated but not observed in any account gathered.

Academic administration sets the class schedule, including the 8:30 AM start that overlaps with the breakfast window, with total authority within that domain and zero formal relationship to any of the three mess-governance actors above. This was tested directly: asked whether anyone — student, Committee, or Office — has ever raised the overlap with Academic administration, the answer was that nobody has really tried. This resolves the question in favor of **inattention rather than refusal** — the absence of a relationship reflects that the bridge has never been attempted, not that it was tried and blocked.

A fifth actor, verified directly from source: the Student Parliament’s elected mess-related roles. IIIT Hyderabad’s Student Parliament, elected via Single Transferable Vote at roughly one representative per 50 students, maintains a **Mess Secretary** and a dedicated **Mess Deputy Secretary for each individual mess** — confirmed for Yuktāhār, Kadamba, and Palash, fetched directly from the Parliament’s own published records rather than a search snippet. Student representation on mess matters is a dedicated elected role per mess, sitting within the Parliament, rather than a seat appointed by the Mess Committee itself. Parliament representatives also hold a standing meeting format with a **Mess Warden** — a title distinct from, and not yet confirmed identical to, the Warden already named above.

A separately-named “Mess Council,” raised earlier as the recipient of a public complaint email, is very likely a naming artifact rather than a real, separate IIIT Hyderabad body: a real Mess Monitoring Council exists at IIT Hyderabad, a different institution with a near-identical name that this Council belongs to, not to IIIT

Hyderabad. A domain-restricted search of IIIT Hyderabad’s own site found no dedicated “Mess Council” page or reference anywhere.

A sharper, still-unresolved ambiguity replaces it: secondhand sources describe what may be two different things both called “Mess Committee” — a Parliament-internal committee made up of elected representatives that negotiates toward the administration on students’ behalf, and, separately, the institute-level, faculty-led policy body described above. Whether these are the same body with mixed membership, or two genuinely separate committees sharing a name, is unresolved and is the sharpest open naming question in the governance structure.

For the majority of specific decisions this system makes — breakfast timing itself, vendor contract terms, portal functionality, waste handling — no source describes who proposes, approves, or can veto a change. This absence, across real interviews and public-source research, is treated as a finding in itself: these processes may not be visible to anyone outside the governance actors themselves.

Authority at a glance

Domain	Proposes	Approves	Confirmed?
Breakfast timing	Unknown — no evidence of anyone ever proposing a change	Unknown	No — precedent unknown
Class timing	Academic administration	Academic administration	Confirmed within its own domain, but disconnected from mess governance entirely
Registration / cancellation rules	Mess Office	Unclear whether Committee sign-off is required	One case (December 2024) only
Menu	Mess Committee, with student input	Mess Committee	Confirmed
Vendor contracts	Unknown	Warden (per the Stakeholder Map)	Stated, never observed in action
Portal / data governance	Unidentified owner	Unknown	No
Mess Cell / informal resale	Students, self-organized	Not applicable — outside formal approval entirely	The market’s existence is the only “approval”
Waste handling	Unknown	The Facilities/Estate team, at most, as a placeholder	No

Only two domains — menu, and the one operational policy change on record — have a nameable proposer and approver. For nearly everything else, no source names who proposes, approves, or can block a change. This is recorded as a finding about the limits of what is currently visible, not treated as though it were resolved.

Identify Formal and Informal Power

Formal power sits with the three governance actors and Academic administration, described above. Four informal actors exercise real influence with no formal standing at all:

- **Roommates and friends** — direct social prompting changes individual attendance decisions in a minor way, though it remains a secondary, not decisive, effect (see the Process Trace for the fuller evidence base — six real student respondents support this reading).

- **The Mess Cell WhatsApp community** — a self-organized resale market demonstrating real, working peer-to-peer coordination capacity. This capacity has, as far as any evidence shows, mostly been applied to individual transactions rather than a collective approach toward governance — with one significant exception, below.
- **Ping**, the student publication — has published on mess issues at least four times found in this research (a November 2024 piece on a unilateral non-veg cancellation, a December 2024 opinion survey, a January 2025 follow-up, and a 2023 piece on an unrelated water-quality issue at the same institution), creating public visibility for problems that might otherwise stay private. No source identifies this visibility alone producing a policy response.
- **Unofficial registration-management tools** — at least one public, open-source tool lets a student manage registration through an AI agent rather than the official portal, described in its own documentation as built “for students of IIIT Hyderabad.” Its existence is confirmed; its adoption and effect on behavior are not.

Analyse Stakeholder Incentives and Motivations

Stated interest vs. what the system rewards vs. observed behaviour

Stakeholder	Stated interest	What the system actually rewards	Observed behaviour	Gap
Students	Convenient, affordable, timely food	Nothing rewards registering accurately — billing is identical either way	Register broadly; attendance varies widely	Large
Mess Office	Not directly stated by any source	Reduced operational workload — its confirmed, stated motive for the one policy change	Tightened cancellation rules	Small — an unusually clean alignment
Mess Committee	Balance student satisfaction against feasibility	Unclear what the Committee itself is rewarded or penalized for	No observed independent action distinct from the Office’s	The least-evidenced pairing in this analysis
Vendors	Contract renewal, predictable volume	Paid against a four-day forecast regardless of actual attendance (payment mechanism unconfirmed)	Continue producing to the forecast	Cannot be resolved without confirming the payment structure
Academic administration	Its own scheduling goals	No incentive of any kind tied to mess outcomes	Total non-engagement	None — this alignment is exactly why the actor is dormant

Stakeholder	Stated interest	What the system actually rewards	Observed behaviour	Gap
Mess Cell participants	Recoup cost on an unused registration	Direct, immediate financial incentive	An active, functioning market	None — the cleanest incentive-behaviour match in this system

Incentive chains

1. Billing tied to registration, not attendance, removes any incentive for a student to register only when genuinely intending to attend — a structural cause, not a personal failing, of the registration-attendance gap. Confirmed.
2. Skip Meal returns nothing to the student, while reselling on Mess Cell returns partial or full value — a student with advance notice has a rational reason to prefer resale over the system’s own designed tool for the same situation. Confirmed directly by real interview data (six respondents: zero used Skip Meal for a return of value; four used Mess Cell in some form).
3. Walk-in pricing set 70-90% above the registered rate creates a standing incentive to register even under real uncertainty about attendance, inflating registration counts independent of any subsequent no-show. This is now directly evidenced — all six respondents interviewed register in advance, none day-by-day.
4. The Mess Office’s confirmed incentive to reduce its own workload produced a policy — tightened cancellation rules — that reduces student flexibility, plausibly increasing rather than decreasing the pattern it targeted. A candidate case of a fix that fails; not yet confirmed by a governance-side account of its actual effect.
5. Academic administration experiences none of the consequences of the class/mess overlap, so the issue never reaches its agenda by any mechanism evidenced so far, and persists indefinitely with no actor positioned to resolve it unilaterally. Confirmed.

Bargaining power and dependency

Students depend on vendors for food itself; vendors do not depend on any individual student, a strongly asymmetric relationship consistent with a walk-in pricing structure that requires no negotiation. Vendors depend on the Mess Office for a forecast fixed four days ahead of service; the Mess Office depends on students to register accurately, but nothing in the billing structure requires accuracy — the one dependency in this system where the party with less to lose controls an input the other party cannot substitute. Academic administration depends on nothing in the mess system, and nothing in the mess system depends on it: not an imbalance, but a total absence of mutual dependency. The Mess Cell market and the formal system are similarly independent of one another, though the market may be quietly absorbing some of the formal system’s waste problem without either side acknowledging the relationship.

Historical precedent

Bakul’s creation, triggered by Kadamba’s non-vegetarian capacity reaching its ceiling, resulted in a new mess being established — a confirmed structural response to a limit. Who raised the issue and through what process remain unknown.

“Let Them Eat Frogs” (November 2024) — a frog was found in Kadamba’s chicken biryani, and the Mess Office responded by unilaterally cancelling non-vegetarian meals at Kadamba without officially communicating the real reason, prompting debate across multiple mail threads. Secondhand, not full-text-verified, but a clean example of unilateral, opaque Mess Office decision-making, preceding the December episode below by about a month.

The December 2024 cancellation-policy tightening, triggered by Mess Office workload concerns compounded by a Kadamba renovation, was issued with no evidenced Committee involvement or student consul-

tation beforehand. Organized pushback did occur: Ping ran a student opinion form that returned majority disappointment, and Parliament’s mess-related representatives reportedly held two meetings with the Mess Office before the policy took effect, then told Ping they were pushing back. The policy was implemented regardless — a real, partial answer to whether organized student action was effective here, though not yet confirmed to be the same episode independently referenced elsewhere in this project as an “organized email effort.”

“**Water Mess**” (2023) — a different domain (drinking-water quality) at the same institution: complaints raised through WhatsApp and email went unaddressed for months despite Parliament requesting water testing, until 38 or more confirmed typhoid cases forced a reactive response. The same complaint-then-ignored-then-crisis-then-reactive-fix shape recurs across two different domains at this institution.

For every other domain examined — breakfast timing specifically, class-timing coordination specifically — no precedent could be found. This is recorded as precedent currently unknown, not assumed to be zero.

Identify Who Can Influence Decisions and Who Cannot

Power asymmetries

- **The Mess Office has more power than students over registration and cancellation rules**, because it holds unilateral operational authority and students hold none — rules can be tightened, as in December 2024, without a confirmed consultation step.
- **Vendors have more power than students over food quality and quantity on a given morning**, because vendors control production and students have no direct channel to them at all.
- **Academic administration has more power than every mess-governance actor combined over the one variable — class start time — most likely to resolve the core overlap**, because it holds total, independent authority over its own domain and mess-side actors have no formal channel to it at all.
- **Students have more power than any formal actor over the accuracy of registration data**, because they are the only source of that data and nothing currently requires it to be accurate — every other actor’s planning rests on an input its own supplier has no reason to keep honest.

Consequence and control

High consequence, low power: students bear the entire visible cost of this system’s central problem — wasted food, lost money, energy crashes — while holding no confirmed authority over any of the domains that produce it: not billing structure, not cancellation rules, not menu weighting by cuisine, not class timing.

Low consequence, high power: Academic administration holds total authority over the one variable most likely to resolve the core overlap and experiences none of the consequences of leaving it unresolved — not a moral failing, since nothing in its formal mandate connects it to mess outcomes, but the structural reason the overlap can persist indefinitely.

Missing voices and missing relationships

Question	Answer
Affected but not represented	Students, on any decision beyond menu content

Question	Answer
Consulted but cannot decide	Students, on the menu specifically — a named structure exists (Mess Secretary and per-mess Deputy Secretaries, elected through the Student Parliament), but whether this seat carries a vote in the institute-level Mess Committee, or only in the separate Parliament-internal committee, is unconfirmed
Decides but does not experience consequences	Academic administration, on class timing
Has data but not authority	The Mess Office, plausibly, if registration/attendance data does not reach the Mess Committee
Has authority but not data	The Mess Committee, plausibly, over menu decisions made without visibility into which cuisine lines actually get eaten versus registered
Implements decisions it did not help design	Vendors, on cancellation-rule changes that directly affect the forecast they must work against
Absorbs consequences created upstream	Serving and kitchen staff, who eat unclaimed food themselves
No formal escalation channel	Any cross-authority issue — specifically the class/mess overlap — has no established path for either side to raise it with the other

Beyond the confirmed absence between Academic administration and every mess-governance actor: no source describes a direct relationship between vendors and students, despite vendors controlling exactly what students experience each morning — everything routes through the Mess Office or the portal instead. No source describes a relationship between the Portal/IT owner and the Mess Committee, despite the Committee presumably depending on that system to enforce whatever it decides.

Coalitions and conflicts

A potential, currently unrealized coalition: students and vendors share an interest in accurate demand signals — students want to avoid double-paying for missed food, and vendors want to avoid over- or under-producing against a forecast. Neither currently has a direct channel to the other; both route through the Mess Office.

Convenience (student interest) against reduced workload (the Mess Office’s confirmed incentive) is not a symmetric negotiation — the Office has demonstrated unilateral authority to resolve this conflict in its own favor, and did so in December 2024. Billing certainty (needed by vendors and the Office for forecasting) against attendance uncertainty (a real feature of student life, not a defect) is a structurally misaligned conflict, not a negotiable one — no rule change on either side removes the underlying uncertainty, only shifts who bears its cost.

Examine Unequal Access to Resources or Opportunities

Resource control

Resource	Controls it	Advantage created
Money (billing)	Mess Office	Sets terms students cannot individually negotiate
Food and kitchen infrastructure	Vendors, per cuisine line	Controls what every other actor ultimately needs
Registration, attendance, and complaint data	Mess Office (presumed); a Portal/IT owner whose identity is unconfirmed	Holds the only evidence base for whether the paradox is improving or worsening
Formal complaint channels (in-app rating, email)	Mess Office, as recipient	One-directional — no confirmed visibility into what happens after submission
Informal escalation (Ping, Mess Cell)	Students and Ping, collectively	Creates two tiers of practical access depending on whether a student knows these channels exist
The four-day procurement lead time	Mess Office and vendors, structurally rather than by choice	Caps how responsive the entire system can be to same-day information, for every actor equally
Institutional legitimacy	The Mess Committee	Not a resource students can acquire individually, only collectively, and only if organized

Students experience the consequences of every resource in this table and control direct access to none of them — not the terms of billing, not the evidence base that would demonstrate the pattern, not the legitimacy needed to be treated as a counterparty rather than a population to be managed.

Leverage analysis

Power and leverage are treated as distinct: power is the capacity to influence a decision; leverage is the capacity for a relatively small action to produce a disproportionately large system effect. The Mess Office holds both, having demonstrated authority and a confirmed instance of a small operational change producing a system-wide behavioral effect. Academic administration holds power without leverage over this specific problem. Students, individually, hold neither — but the Mess Cell market demonstrates that students collectively possess real, functioning organizational capacity, and this capacity has also been directed at governance directly at least once. This is better described as **exercised-but-unmeasured leverage** than purely sleeping leverage.

Sleeping stakeholders

Academic administration remains the clearest case: total authority over class timing, zero relationship to any mess-governance actor, and no incentive of any kind pulling it toward engagement.

The Mess Committee’s chair, if the secondhand report of a faculty chair holds, is a more subtle case — a person with plausible informal, collegial access to other faculty and academic-side actors that no student-only channel possesses, with no evidence this access has ever been used to raise the mess/academic overlap.

Students, collectively, occupy a genuinely ambiguous position: the Mess Cell market proves organizing capacity exists at the peer-to-peer level, and an organized effort has also been directed at governance itself at least once. The capacity is not purely unexercised — but what that effort targeted and whether it produced any actual change are both unknown. The open question has narrowed from “has this capacity ever been aimed at governance” to “what happened the one time it was.”

Stakeholder Power-Interest/Leverage Map

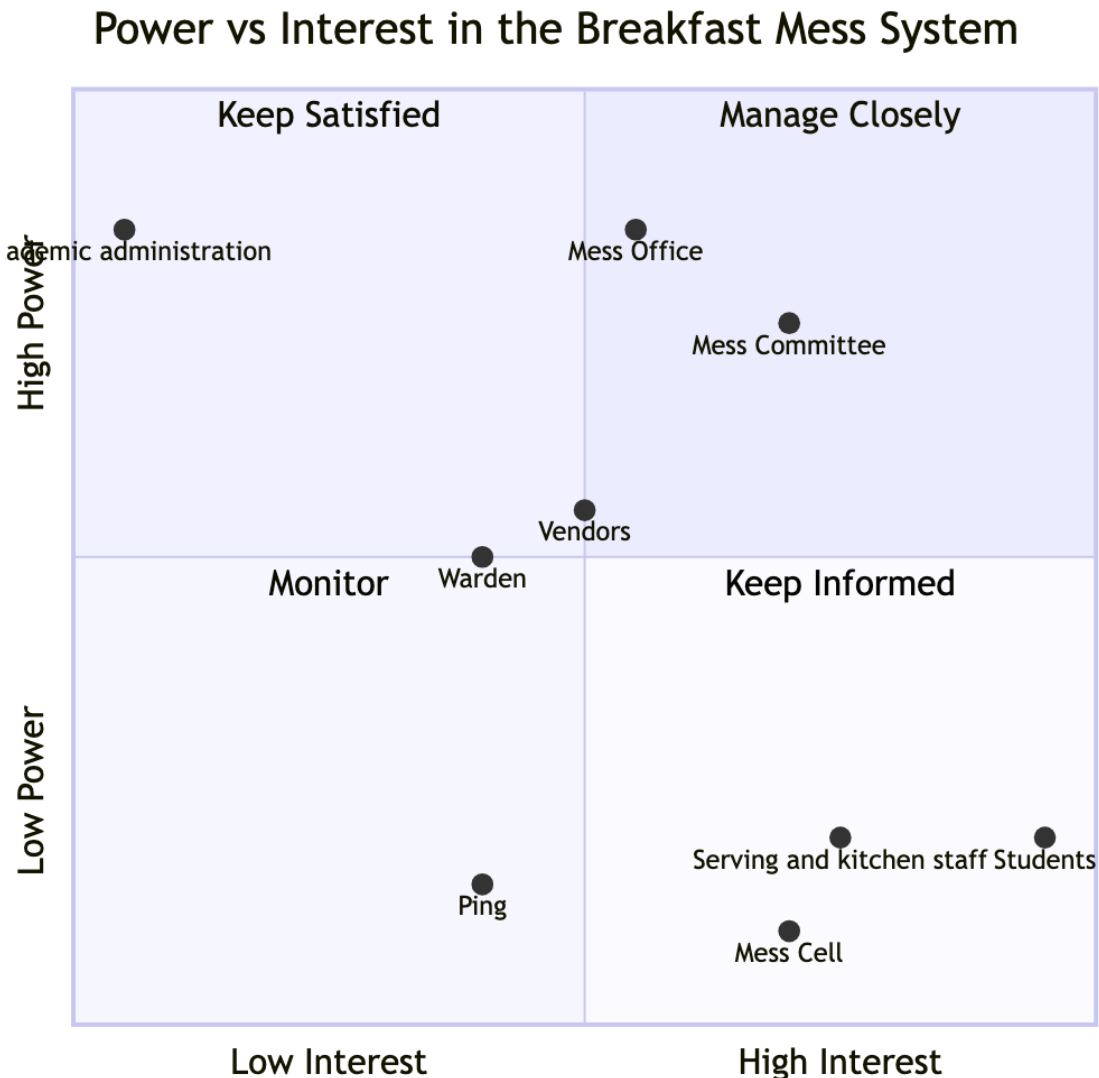


Figure 1: Power vs. Interest

Coordinates on this chart are ordinal placements for visual clarity, not measured values — the relative position of each actor across quadrants is the finding, not the specific decimal location. **Mess Committee** — high power over menu, unconfirmed power over anything else. **Mess Office** — the highest-confidence “high power” placement in this system, with a demonstrated instance of exercising authority and changing behavior. **Academic administration** — high power over class timing, essentially zero power or interest specifically over mess outcomes. **Vendors** — moderate power over food quality and quantity within the four-day constraint, low confirmed interest beyond contract terms. **Students** — very high interest, very low formal power: the textbook mismanaged “Keep Informed” quadrant. **Mess Cell and Ping** — low formal power by design, moderate interest, with actual influence running through informal rather than positional channels.

As with the chart above, coordinates are ordinal placements only.

Dotted lines mark informal or unconfirmed channels; “NO FORMAL CHANNEL” marks a confirmed absence of any relationship — most consequentially, between Academic administration and every one of the three

Power vs Leverage

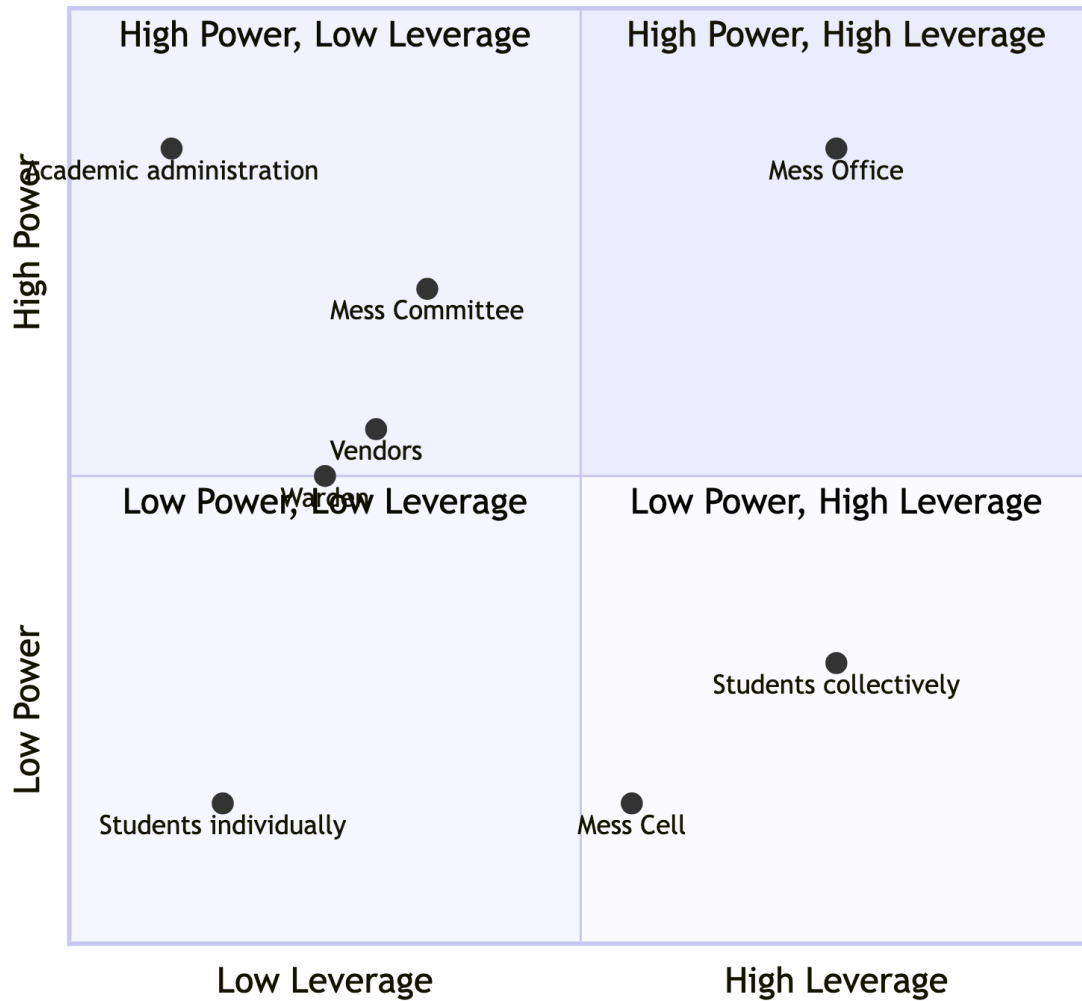


Figure 2: Power vs. Leverage

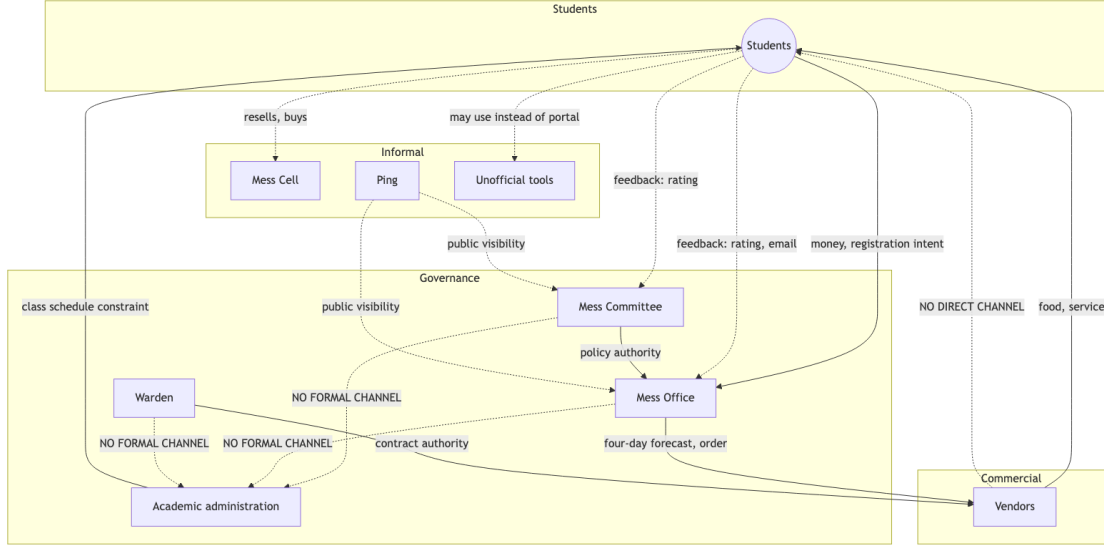


Figure 3: Power and Information Flow Network

mess-governance actors.

Implications for System Behaviour

The distribution of power described above does not merely coexist with the Breakfast Paradox — it plausibly produces and sustains it. Billing without an attendance incentive removes any structural pressure on the one actor (the student) whose behavior most directly determines the outcome. The one confirmed governance action on record was taken to serve an internal operational goal, not the paradox itself, and may have tightened rather than loosened the underlying pattern. The actor best positioned to resolve the paradox’s second major driver — the schedule overlap — remains entirely disconnected from every governance actor who might otherwise raise it, confirmed to reflect inattention rather than a refusal. And the one channel that could plausibly generate collective pressure for change — the students themselves — has been aimed at governance at least once, through an organized effort whose exact subject and outcome remain to be confirmed. The paradox may therefore be sustained less by an absence of channels than by channels that exist but whose effectiveness has never been measured or followed up on.

Key Findings

1. **Registration without an attendance incentive.** Billing tied to registration count, not attendance, creates no pressure on students to register only when genuinely intending to attend — the most solidly evidenced structure in this system.
2. **Unilateral operational authority in the Mess Office.** The Office issued a real policy change (December 2024) with no evidenced Committee or student involvement beforehand. Whether this generalizes to a standing pattern needs governance-source confirmation.
3. **Total independence of Academic administration from mess governance.** No formal mandate connects the two systems in either direction, confirmed to reflect inattention rather than active refusal.
4. **Asymmetric dependency on registration accuracy.** The party with the least to lose from inaccurate data — students — controls the one input everyone else’s forecasting depends on.
5. **Skip Meal as a dominated strategy.** Skip Meal returns nothing to the student; resale returns partial or full value, making resale the rational choice whenever advance notice exists — mechanically plausible given confirmed pricing, and now directly confirmed by real interview data.
6. **Exercised-but-unmeasured collective leverage.** Real self-organizing capacity exists (Mess Cell)

and has also been aimed at governance directly at least once, through an organized effort — the December 2024 Ping-survey-and-Parliament-negotiation episode is a strong but unconfirmed candidate match.

7. **A confirmed feedback input with an unconfirmed output.** Three real channels — in-app rating, email, Ping coverage — carry input into the system; none has a confirmed instance of producing a decision.

Outstanding Data Collection

The following items depend on a mess-committee or mess-vendor source and have not yet been confirmed; **this data will be collected and submitted later**, once that interview round is completed:

- Vendor compensation structure (fixed, per-meal, or per-registration) — determines whether vendors bear any cost of the registration-attendance gap.
- A specific instance of vendor bargaining or contract renegotiation.
- Who actually sees and acts on per-meal ratings once submitted.
- Whether the December 2024 Ping-survey-and-Parliament-negotiation episode is the specific “organized email effort” this project has otherwise only heard about secondhand, and if so, whether “opposition registered, policy implemented anyway” is the complete account of whether it worked. This is the single highest-priority open question in this analysis.
- Whether Committee approval is formally required for a Mess Office operational change, and whether the Parliament-internal mess committee and the institute-level Mess Committee are the same body or two different ones sharing a name.

Current-State Process Map / Process Trace

IIIT Hyderabad Breakfast Mess System

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Overview

The Stakeholder Map says who is involved. This trace says what actually happens, step by step, including the workarounds — how the system actually operates rather than how it is supposed to operate. Confirmed facts describe billing and cancellation at the monthly level, but registration itself also runs on a monthly cadence, sitting on top of a separate daily attendance decision — two different timescales that this trace keeps distinct rather than collapsing into one loop.

This trace covers the student-facing half of the breakfast process, established from six real respondents (five interviewed 2026-09-06, plus one original respondent interviewed 2026-09-03) and the confirmed portal mechanics. It stops at the kitchen door: everything from the point a registration reaches the kitchen onward is not yet visible from any source gathered, and **that data will be collected and submitted later**, once a mess-committee or mess-vendor interview is completed.

Conduct Interviews and Observations

Six real respondents have been interviewed to date. Direct physical observation of a live breakfast service has not yet taken place — the window for this cycle had already passed before this project began collecting data, and a full observation protocol (7:15 AM setup through post-close) is prepared and ready to run.

Source	Represents	Reveals	Cannot establish
Original respondent (2026-09-03)	1 habitual skipper, general system informant	Full system mechanics — registration, billing, QR, Mess Cell, governance — and one person’s skip reasons	Whether reasons generalize; anything about mess-side operations
Portal screenshots	The registration/billing platform itself	Real prices, capacities, registration counts, the Skip Meal-versus-Cancel distinction, the rating feature, random allocation	Actual attendance — registration is not attendance — and anything about kitchen or staff operations
Five student interviews (2026-09-06)	2 daily eaters, 3 skippers	Real decision sequences, queue and crowding experience, item-specific run-outs, registration habits, Mess Cell use, timing preferences, self-estimated spend on unused meals	The kitchen and vendor side entirely; whether six respondents represent the wider population
Power-Interest/Leverage analysis (Task 3)	Governance structure	Formal and informal power, precedent, the Student Parliament’s Mess Secretary role	Kitchen and vendor operations; most decision-domain authority

System visibility: everything from a student’s own decision through billing is directly visible in this evidence base. Everything from “registration reaches the kitchen” onward — how a preparation quantity is decided, when cooking begins, how portions are estimated per item, what happens to unclaimed food beyond staff eating some of it, and whether any of this data reaches a decision-maker — is not visible from any source gathered so far. This boundary is not filled with assumptions anywhere in this document.

Trace Decisions and Interactions

Two timescales matter and are kept separate. Registration runs on a **monthly cycle**: three of six respondents specifically describe registering “for a month,” not day-by-day and not weekly — a wider decoupling between the registration decision and the morning-of attendance decision than this project’s own earlier drafts assumed.

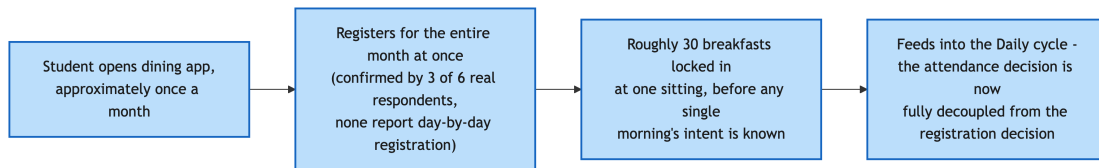


Figure 1: Monthly Registration Cycle

The **daily cycle** is where the actual go/skip decision happens, well evidenced across all six respondents:

Decision points, supported by evidence only

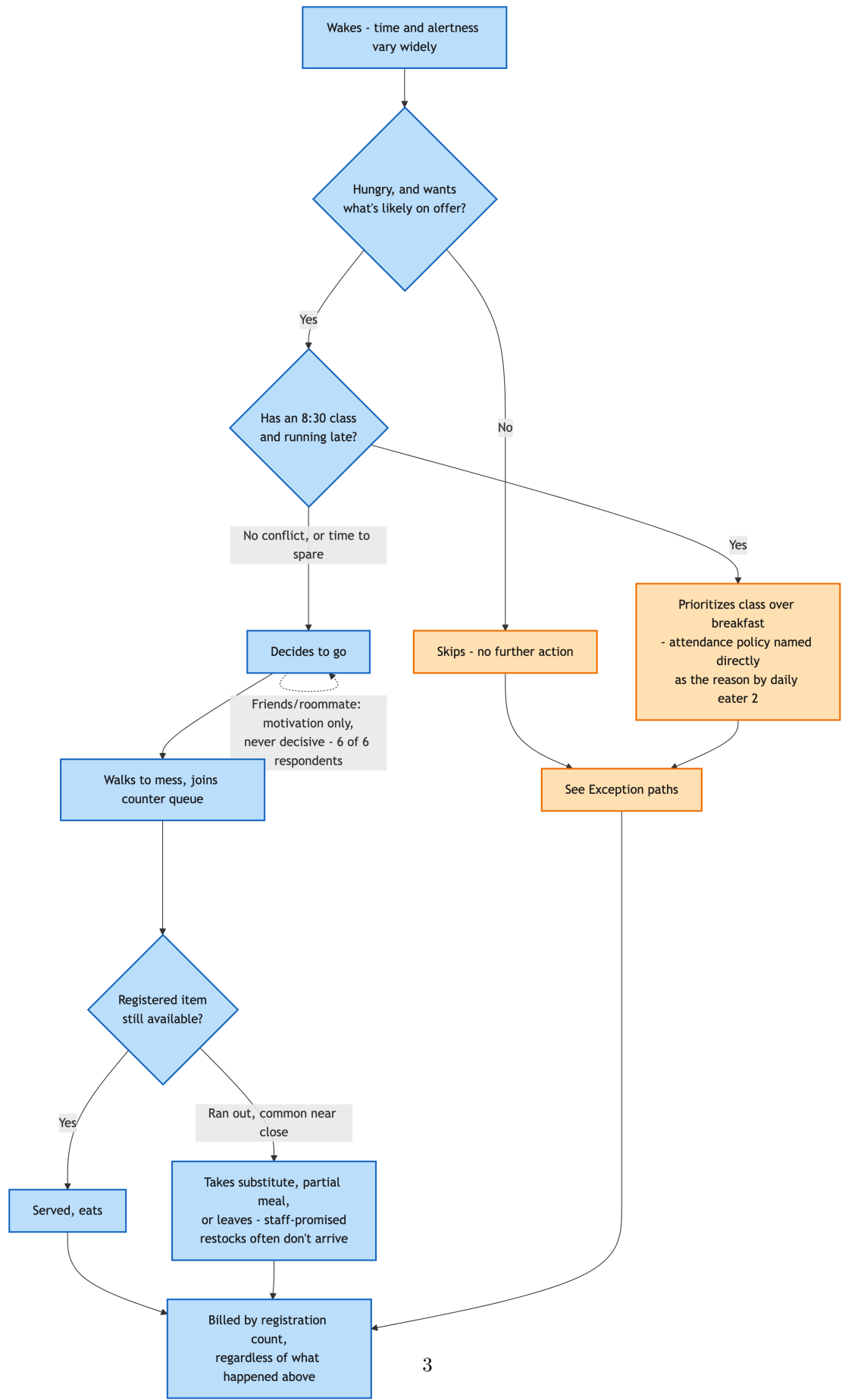


Figure 2: Daily Attendance-Decision Cycle

Decision	Who	When	Constraint	Options observed
Register or not	Student	Monthly, in advance	Popular messes (Kadamba) fill up	All six respondents register in advance; none day-by-day
Which mess	Student	At registration	Capacity, competition for popular messes	Kadamba chosen by four of six respondents; Bakul mentioned once
Go or skip, that morning	Student	On waking	8:30 class and attendance policy (named directly by one respondent)	Go; skip; go later — the central real decision point, evidenced across all six
Check the app before deciding	Student	Before or instead of deciding	A crowd-check and menu-view feature exists	Checked by one of six respondents; ignored by the rest
Wait for or wake friends	Student	On waking	Friend's own wake state	Wakes them and goes regardless if they don't respond (two of six); not a factor at all (three of six); positive but non-determining (one of six)
Cancel a registration	Student	Days ahead, planned	A cap of five per meal type per month	Used by most respondents at least occasionally; not used by one respondent specifically because they forget
Use Skip Meal	Student	Same day or ahead	Returns no money	Never used by any of the six respondents who addressed it
Resell or buy via Mess Cell	Student	When a registration is known to go unused	Informal, no guaranteed buyer	Used, bought and/or sold, by four of six; a passive observer for one; unused for breakfast specifically by another
Eat as a walk-in	Student	Same day, unregistered	Price markup	Used for snacks, not breakfast (one); used for breakfast (one); never (three)

A hypothesis this data disconfirms. Earlier drafts of this project treated social company as a meaningful driver of attendance. Six real respondents now tell a more specific, consistently weaker story: peer presence is at most a motivational add-on, never the deciding factor. No respondent describes skipping because a friend didn't go, or attending only because one did.

Document Formal and Informal Rules

Rule	Enforced by	Behavioural effect	Rationale known?
Registration required	Mess Office / portal	All six respondents register in advance, monthly	Ties billing to registration
Cancellation cap (5 per meal type per month)	Mess Office / portal	Used by most respondents; one respondent explicitly forgets to use it	Limits uncanceled no-shows
Skip Meal, no refund	Mess Office / portal	Never used by any respondent addressing it — zero of six	Reduces kitchen preparation, not billing
Walk-in markup	Mess Office / vendor	Used sparingly; two respondents avoid it for breakfast specifically	Confirmed pricing incentive
Registered vs. random allocation	Portal	One respondent explicitly relies on random allocation rather than active registration — the first real, first-person confirmation of this mechanism actually being used	Mechanism now confirmed in real use, not only as a settings toggle
Mess closing at 9:30	Mess	Four of six respondents explicitly ask for this to be extended	Rationale for the specific cutoff unknown

Informal norms — unwritten, widely shared expectations, not solving a specific problem: registering for the whole month rather than day-by-day, appearing to be the path of least resistance for most respondents rather than a deliberate strategy; going early specifically to avoid queues, one respondent’s explicit strategy; checking the app’s menu before deciding to attend, one respondent only, not clearly a shared norm.

Workarounds — adaptations specifically compensating for a gap in the formal system: Mess Cell resale, used by four of six in some form, compensating for Skip Meal’s lack of a refund; eating snacks or a later meal instead, compensating for skipping without an official cost-recovery path; scarcity-driven early registration for Kadamba specifically, compensating for a popular mess filling up — a workaround around capacity, not around billing.

Formal versus informal divergence

Where they diverge	Formal design	Actual behaviour
Registration cadence	Designed to be per-meal or flexible; the portal supports day-by-day	Universally monthly across six respondents — a de facto norm the system permits but did not design toward
Skip Meal	Designed to reduce kitchen waste	Functionally unused — zero of six real usage

Where they diverge	Formal design	Actual behaviour
Cancellation	Designed as the correct tool for planned non-attendance	Used inconsistently; at least one respondent doesn't use it simply because they forget, not by considered choice
Random allocation	A minor settings toggle in the formal design	For at least one real respondent, this is their actual registration mechanism, not a backup
Item availability at close	Designed to run until 9:30	Staff make informal, unfulfilled promises to restock before close

Identify Negotiation and Escalation Mechanisms

No respondent in this round describes a working escalation path. Asked directly whether they or anyone they know tried to get a mess rule or timing changed, every one of the five new respondents said no. One respondent notes the mess does make reactive, immediate fixes to specific problems — a run-out, a technical error — but this is operational firefighting, not a rule-change mechanism, and is explicitly distinguished from what the question asked:

STUDENT → ? NO VISIBLE ESCALATION PATH FOR RULE OR TIMING CHANGES

STUDENT → MESS (reactive, same-incident-only fixes) → confirmed, but distinct

This absence is not a data gap to apologize for — it is a systems finding, identical in shape to the Power Analysis Brief's central governance finding (feedback inputs exist, outputs don't), now independently corroborated by five more respondents at the student-experience level rather than only the governance-structure level.

Track Exceptions, Workarounds and Dependencies

Dependencies

Eating breakfast at the mess depends on: waking with enough time and alertness — the single most commonly cited constraint — together with the desired item still being available at time of arrival (run-outs confirmed by at least three of six respondents, directly or by reputation), no conflicting class-attendance pressure (explicit for one respondent), and the mess still being within its serving window (the 9:30 cutoff is the single most-requested change across respondents). One step upstream, each of these depends on a process this project cannot yet see: item availability depends on a kitchen-side preparation-quantity decision, itself bound by the four-day lead time on which the Mess Office places its order with each vendor (confirmed in the Power Analysis Brief) — nothing in the process traced above lets same-day registration, cancellation, or Skip Meal activity change what is actually cooked, since the order is already fixed four days out. The attendance-policy pressure separately depends on academic administration's own scheduling — confirmed disconnected from mess governance, per the same brief.

Key Findings

1. The registration-attendance gap is not one mechanism but several, now evidenced distinctly: habitual monthly over-registration, scarcity-driven defensive registration at Kadamba specifically, random allocation, and simple forgetting — different behaviours with different fixes, previously blurred together.
2. Peer influence, previously treated as a meaningful lever, is disconfirmed as a decision-determining factor by six real respondents — it is at most a motivational add-on.

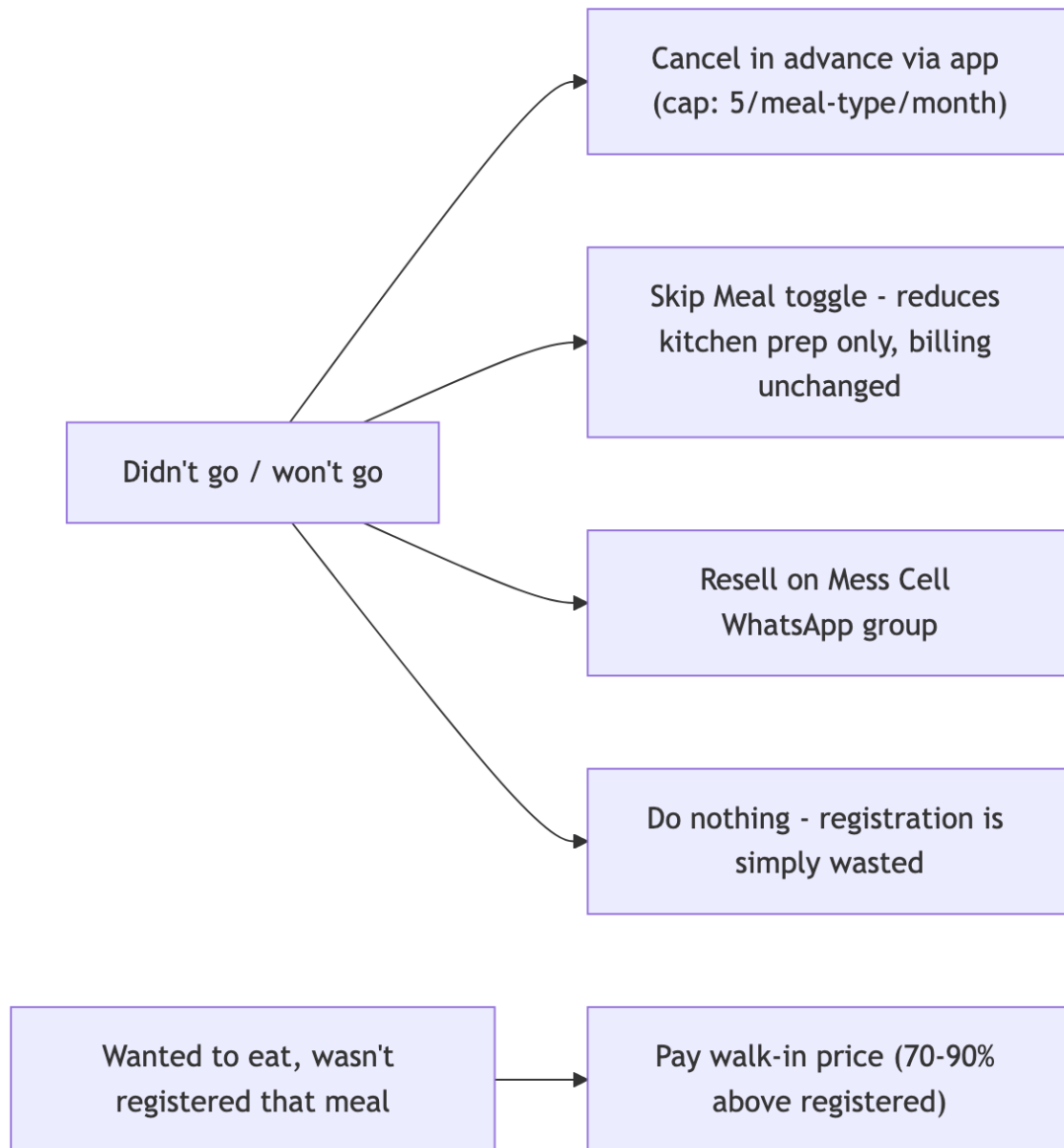


Figure 3: Exception and Workaround Paths

3. The escalation-path absence identified in the Power Analysis Brief is now independently corroborated at the student-experience level.
4. A genuinely new finding: **broken restock promises** — staff say an item will return before close and it doesn't. This is a trust and service-quality finding with no prior documentation anywhere in this project.
5. Two respondents converge independently on a claim that only around 30% of registered students actually attend, and that the mess still struggles to serve even that smaller group well — the paradox may not only be about wasted food from no-shows, but also under-provisioning for the students who do show up. This claim is not sourced or attributed in either transcript and is treated as an unverified respondent impression, not a confirmed figure.

Outstanding Data Collection

The kitchen and vendor side of this process is entirely unobserved. **This data will be collected and submitted later**, once mess-committee and mess-vendor interviews are completed, and once direct observation of a live service window is conducted. Specifically outstanding:

- What quantity the kitchen actually prepares against — live registrations, a historical average, or another figure — and whether the unverified “~30%” attendance claim is real.
- Whether a Skip Meal toggle set the same morning is subtracted from a preparation number, or has no effect at all.
- Why specific items (idli, puri, bhatura, fruit) run out ahead of others — a forecasting problem or a popularity mismatch.
- What a staff “restock promise” actually means operationally — a genuine intention that fails, or a placating non-commitment.
- What happens to unclaimed food beyond staff eating some of it, already confirmed — whether any of it is measured, discarded, or reused.
- Whether any waste or shortfall data reaches the Mess Office, the Mess Committee, or anyone with authority to adjust future preparation.

A direct observation protocol is prepared and ready to run across the full 7:30-9:30 AM window in 30-minute intervals, recording queue length, arrival rate, and item availability only — no personally identifying information, consistent with this project's own research discipline.

System Timeline / Behaviour-Over-Time Map

IIIT Hyderabad Breakfast Mess System

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Overview

This map asks a different question than the Process Trace: not how the process works, but what pattern emerges when it repeats, across people and across time. No numeric trend is invented anywhere below — where only qualitative, respondent-sourced statements exist, they are presented as such, not converted into a chart implying a precision the evidence does not have.

Timescales actually supported by evidence: **within one morning** (well evidenced, six respondents describe it directly), **across a week** — an early-class day against a non-early-class day (evidenced, one respondent states the trade-off explicitly), **across a month** (evidenced indirectly — monthly registration is the universal pattern, and the cancellation cap operates on a monthly cycle), and **across a semester** (evidenced — six respondents each give a semester-level trend statement, the strongest temporal evidence available). No evidence exists at the scale of multiple semesters or years, and none is claimed.

Collect Historical Versions, Records or Observations

Respondent	Behaviour	Frequency	Trigger	Time horizon
Original respondent (2026-09-03)	Habitual skipper	Most mornings	Intermittent fasting, poor hostel mess quality historically, late sleep	Longstanding habit

Respondent	Behaviour	Frequency	Trigger	Time horizon
Daily eater 1	Near-daily attender	5-6 of 7 mornings	Habit; late-night work causes the rare skip	More regular this semester than before
Daily eater 2	Most-days attender	Most days	8:30 class plus late sleep causes skips; class-attendance policy is explicitly prioritized over breakfast	No explicit before/after comparison given
Skip-1	Light eater	Roughly once a week	Appetite-driven, menu-checked	Changed since just before classes started this semester; direction implied, not explicit
Skip-2	Non-eater	Zero this semester	Not hungry that early; eats after 10-10:30 instead	Zero for the entire current semester
Skip-3	Declining attender	Rare, was more regular	Late sleep leading to no hunger	Declining specifically over the last three to six weeks

The six real respondents do **not** agree on a single direction. One reports attendance increasing this semester; one reports a specific recent decline over three to six weeks; one has been at zero all semester; the rest give no clear directional trend. There is no single “the paradox is worsening” or “improving” claim this dataset supports — six individuals are moving in different directions simultaneously, which is itself the honest system-level finding at this evidence level, not a gap to be resolved by more interviews of the same kind.

No records-based (as opposed to recall-based) historical or observational data exists yet. Direct observation of a live service window has not been conducted; a 30-minute-interval protocol across the full 7:30-9:30 AM window is prepared and ready to run, and **this data will be collected and submitted later**.

Develop Timelines

Within-morning pattern, reconciled

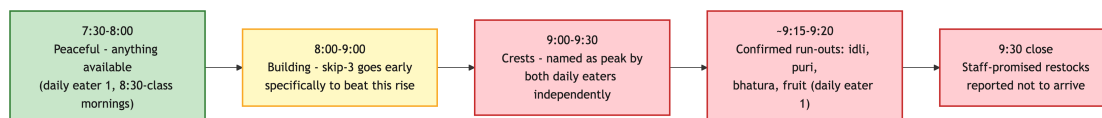


Figure 1: Crowd Build Through the Breakfast Window

What first looked like two competing peak-crowding claims — one respondent naming 8:00-9:00, two others naming 9:00-9:30 — reconciles into one continuously building crowd that crests just before the 9:30 close: the respondent who names the earlier window describes deliberately arriving early specifically to avoid the crowd, meaning they are describing the rising portion of the same curve the later respondents experience at its crest, not a separate, earlier peak. This is the working hypothesis, not a measurement — direct observation or QR-scan timestamps would still confirm the exact shape, but it resolves what first looked like a contradiction into one consistent pattern rather than leaving two claims in unresolved tension.

Provisional system-level timeline

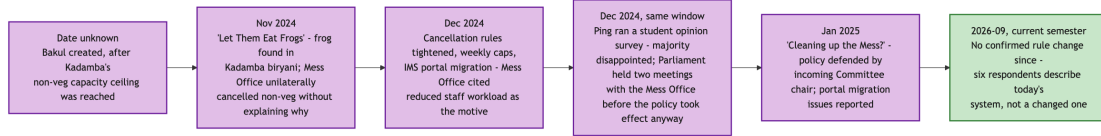


Figure 2: Provisional System Timeline

This timeline is cross-referenced from the Power Analysis Brief’s precedent research, kept here only as the timeline view this deliverable specifically asks for. No respondent in the 2026-09-06 round mentions a recent rule change — the six respondents interviewed describe the current system, not a system in the middle of changing.

Identify Significant Changes and Their Triggers

Date or period	Change	Trigger
Date unknown	Bakul created	Kadamba’s non-vegetarian capacity ceiling was reached
November 2024	“Let Them Eat Frogs” — Kadamba non-vegetarian meals unilaterally cancelled	A frog found in Kadamba’s chicken biryani
December 2024	Cancellation rules tightened, weekly caps, portal migration	Mess Office workload concerns, compounded by a Kadamba renovation
December 2024, same window	Ping student opinion survey; two Parliament-Mess Office meetings	Organized pushback against the cancellation-rule tightening
January 2025	“Cleaning up the Mess?” — policy defended by the incoming Committee chair; portal migration issues reported	Continuation of the December 2024 episode
2026-09, current semester	No confirmed rule change	—

Examine Feedback Loops and Recurring Patterns

R1 — “Shifting the Burden” via Mess Cell (reinforcing — sustains the dysfunction rather than growing it unboundedly). Confirmed on its central mechanism: zero of six respondents who addressed Skip Meal have ever used it, and the respondent who explained why did so in exactly the terms this project’s incentive analysis predicted — it doesn’t return the money. Four of six respondents have used Mess Cell in some form.

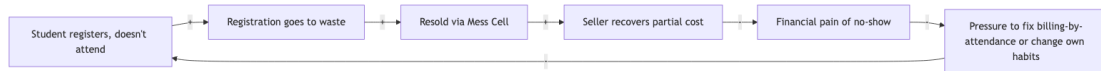


Figure 3: R1 — Mess Cell as a Shifting-the-Burden Loop

The informal resale market is a symptomatic relief valve that makes the underlying problem — billing that does not track attendance — tolerable enough that nobody is ever forced to fix the fundamental cause. The workaround’s success is exactly what lets the root cause persist. Every link in this loop is now directly

evidenced except the final “reduces pressure to fix billing” step, which remains a structurally plausible inference, not something any respondent stated directly.

B1 — Kitchen Waste Control via Skip Meal (balancing, but incomplete — a Fix That Fails). Skip Meal’s zero real usage across six respondents strengthens this finding: this balancing loop may not be closing on the kitchen side in practice at all, not merely failing to address the student side as previously argued.

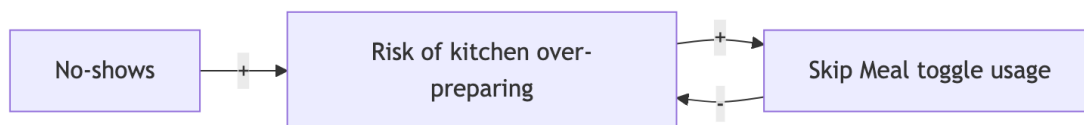


Figure 4: B1 — Skip Meal Balances Kitchen Preparation, Not Billing

B2 — Capacity Redistribution (weak or broken). One respondent explicitly registers for the whole month specifically because “Kadamba is hard to get and it gets full” — direct, first-person evidence of scarcity-driven demand concentration on the popular mess, rather than organic redistribution to Bakul or Palash.

A new candidate loop — under-provisioning for real attendees. Two independent daily-eater respondents converge on a claim that the mess cannot adequately serve even the smaller group who do attend, because preparation may be calibrated to something other than actual peak-clustered demand:

Registration inflated by several mechanisms (habitual, scarcity-driven, random allocation) -> true attendance rate low relative to registration -> preparation possibly calibrated toward the low true-attendance number, not peak-hour clustering -> peak-hour run-outs occur even though total food may be "enough" on average -> attendees who do show up have a poor experience

This is presented as a hypothesis with two real, independent, converging respondent statements behind its first half, and an unconfirmed second half — not as a settled loop.

Identify Unintended Consequences

Rule or action	Intended function	Observed response	Unintended consequence
Cancellation cap	Limit uncanceled no-shows	Students use cancellation inconsistently; one respondent doesn't use it because they forget	The cap constrains a behaviour that at least some students don't reliably perform for reasons unrelated to the cap itself
Walk-in markup	Discourage same-day uncertainty	Monthly advance registration, universal across all six respondents	Registration counts are inflated independent of true attendance intent
Skip Meal, no refund	Reduce kitchen waste	Zero real usage across six respondents	The tool may not be reducing kitchen waste in practice at all, since nobody uses it
Mess Cell (informal, not a designed rule)	Not applicable	Absorbs unused registrations for some students	May reduce visible pressure to fix the underlying billing model, while genuinely helping the students who use it

Key Findings

1. No single population-level trend exists — real respondents move in different directions simultaneously. Any future claim that the paradox is getting worse, or better, needs to specify for whom, not assert it for students generally.
2. What first looked like two competing peak-crowding claims reconciles into one continuously building crowd cresting near the 9:30 close — still recall-based, not measured, so direct observation remains the way to confirm the exact shape.
3. Skip Meal’s real usage rate in this sample is zero — the strongest evidence yet for treating it as a non-functioning tool in practice, not only poorly incentivized in theory.
4. A new candidate systemic loop — under-provisioning for actual, not just registered, attendees — is independently corroborated by two respondents and adds a previously missing half to the waste narrative: this is not only about food cooked for no-shows, it may also be about food not cooked for real attendees.

Outstanding Data Collection

The following require quantitative, records-based data or a mess-committee/mess-vendor source, and **will be collected and submitted later**:

- A realistic minimum of four to eight weeks of daily registration and attendance data per mess — a full semester would be materially better for anything involving exam-period or deadline-clustering effects, which no current evidence speaks to at all.
- Whether the true peak window matches either respondent claim, or is something else entirely — resolvable only by direct observation or QR-scan timestamps.
- Whether the registration-to-attendance gap actually sits near the unverified “~30%” figure two respondents independently cited.
- Whether Skip Meal usage, even if rare in a larger sample, correlates with any measurable reduction in specific-item run-outs.
- Whether attendance actually declines in the specific three-to-six-week window one respondent identified, and whether it correlates with any academic-calendar event.
- When Skip Meal was introduced and why; when the five-cancellation rule was set at exactly five; whether breakfast timing has ever been different from 7:30-9:30 — none of these are addressed by any source gathered so far and are appropriate governance-interview questions, not resolvable from student accounts alone.

Not yet claimed, and not to be treated as established until this data lands: that breakfast attendance is declining or rising across the student population as a whole; that the mess is definitively under-provisioning relative to real demand; that either named window is definitively the peak; that Skip Meal has zero effect on kitchen behaviour rather than simply zero observed student-side usage; and any numeric trend over time for any variable.